

David and Ingres

The pre-eminent Neoclassical painter, Jacques-Louis David (1748–1825) had an academic style of history painting that suited the mood of the time. In 1774, he won the Prix de Rome, enabling him to study for five years at the French Academy in Rome. Here, he discovered a fascination for classical art and antiquities. Back in Paris, he became as passionate about politics as art, narrowly avoiding the guillotine twice for revolutionary activities. Appreciating his patriotism, clarity and purity of style, in 1802 Napoleon made him a knight of his new Legion of Honour.

After training briefly with David, Jean-Auguste-Dominique Ingres (1780–1867) also won the Prix de Rome. He spent 17 years in Italy, studying Renaissance art and making a living selling pencil portraits. He also began painting bathers, a theme that he revisited throughout his career. His elongated, smooth-skinned nudes epitomized his belief in accuracy of line. By the late 19th century, he was celebrated as David's equal for his skilful paintings with cool colours, smooth contours and imperceptible brushmarks.



David, *The Death of Marat*, 1793